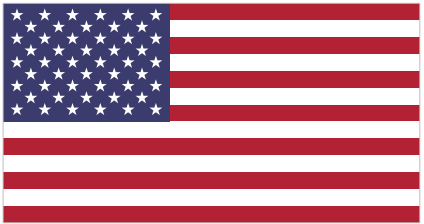
Cultural Differences

The USA and Austria



Warm-up

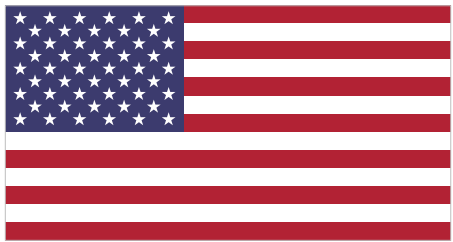
Warm-up

What do you know about American culture?

The Pledge of Allegiance

The Pledge of Allegiance

I pledge allegiance to the Flag
of the United States of America,
and to the Republic
for which it stands,
one Nation under God,
indivisible,
with liberty and justice for all.



Stand, face the flag, right hand over your heart.

Reflection

- What did that feel like?
- Do you think this is still practiced in schools?
- What time period do you think this is from?

History behind the Pledge

- **1885:** First version by Captain George Thatcher Balch, a Union Army officer in the Civil War
  - *"We give our heads and our hearts to God and our country; one country, one language, one flag!"*
- **1892:** Francis Bellamy, a Baptist minister, writes a new version for the 400th anniversary of Columbus's arrival in America
  - Published in *The Youth's Companion*, a children's magazine that also sold flags to schools
- **1923–24:** "my Flag" becomes "the Flag of the United States of America"
  - So that immigrants would not be thinking of the flag of their home country

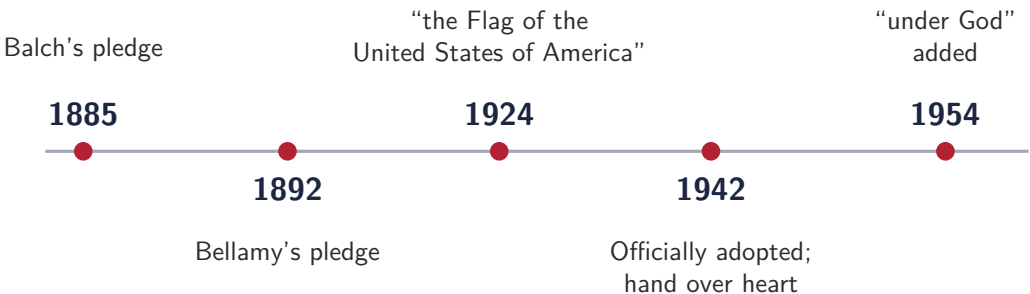
History behind the Pledge

- **1942:** Congress officially adopts the Pledge
- The original "Bellamy salute" (right arm stretched out) looked too much like the Nazi salute
  - Replaced with the hand over the heart
- **Flag Day, 1954:** President Eisenhower adds "under God"
  - Cold War: setting America apart from "godless" Soviet communism



Students giving the Bellamy salute, 1941

The Pledge over time



What does this show about American culture?

- Loyalty and patriotism
- Unity? — “one Nation . . . indivisible”
- Religion in public life — “under God”
- Turning immigrants into Americans



San Francisco, 1942. Weeks later, many of these Japanese American children were sent to internment camps. Photo: Dorothea Lange

Legal challenges

- **1940:** *Minersville v. Gobitis* — schools *may* force students to recite the Pledge; Jehovah's Witness children who refused were expelled
- **1943:** *West Virginia State Board of Education v. Barnette* — the Supreme Court reverses itself: reciting the Pledge cannot be compulsory
- **2004:** *Elk Grove v. Newdow* — a father challenges "under God"; the Court dismisses the case on a technicality
- **Today:** most states require schools to lead the Pledge daily — but students may stay silent



U.S. Supreme Court. Photo: Joe Ravi, CC BY-SA 3.0

Barnette (1943)

> *"If there is any fixed star in our constitutional constellation, it is that no official, high or petty, can prescribe what shall be orthodox in politics, nationalism, religion, or other matters of opinion or force citizens to confess by word or act their faith therein."*

— Justice Robert H. Jackson, majority opinion

Think

What part of American culture or law
might lead the Supreme Court to this decision?

Separation of Church and State

The First Amendment (1791)

> *"Congress shall make no law respecting an establishment of religion, or prohibiting the free exercise thereof; or abridging the freedom of speech, or of the press . . . "*

- **Establishment clause:** no official state religion
- **Free exercise clause:** everyone may practice (or not practice) any religion

Text Analysis

Thomas Jefferson, *Letter to the Danbury Baptist Association*, 1802



> *"Believing with you that religion is a matter which lies solely between Man & his God, that he owes account to none other for his faith or his worship, that the legitimate powers of government reach actions only, & not opinions, I contemplate with sovereign reverence that act of the whole American people which declared that their legislature should 'make no law respecting an establishment of religion, or prohibiting the free exercise thereof,' thus building* ***a wall of separation between Church & State****. Adhering to this expression of the supreme will of the nation in behalf of the rights of conscience, I shall see with sincere satisfaction the progress of those sentiments which tend to restore to man all his natural rights, convinced he has no natural right in opposition to his social duties."*

Church and State in Austria vs. the US: at school

In Austria	In the US
A cross must hang in every classroom where most students are Christian	Unconstitutional (*Stone v. Graham*, 1980) — though new Ten Commandments laws in Louisiana and Texas are being fought in court
Religion class in public schools, taught by teachers approved by the church and paid by the state	Schools may teach *about* religion, but not practice it; no school prayer (*Engel v. Vitale*, 1962)
The state pays the teachers at Catholic private schools	Very limited public money for religious schools

Church and State in Austria vs. the US: public life

In Austria	In the US
Church contribution (*Kirchenbeitrag*) required by a state law; churches can sue members who don't pay	Churches are private and live on voluntary donations
16 officially recognized religious communities; a 1933 treaty with the Vatican (*Konkordat*) is still in force	The government does not recognize or rank religions
Most public holidays are Catholic (Corpus Christi, Assumption, All Saints, ...)	Christmas is the only religious federal holiday
Shops closed on Sundays	Most shops open; rare Sunday-closing laws are allowed only for non-religious reasons ("a day of rest")

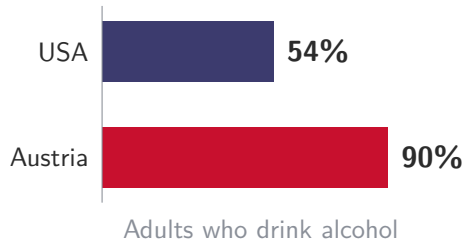
The American paradox

- The US separates church and state much more strictly than Austria ...
- ... yet Americans are far more religious than Austrians
  - "In God We Trust" is printed on every dollar bill
  - Presidents end speeches with "God bless America"
  - "under God" is in the Pledge
- **Discuss:** How does the separation of church and state change American culture? Could it even make religion *stronger*?

Drinking Culture

Who drinks?

- Only 54% of Americans drink alcohol — tied for a record low (Gallup, 2026)
  - 71% in the 1970s; 62% as recently as 2023
- Austria: around 90%
- Legal drinking age:
  - US: **21**
  - Austria: **16** (beer & wine), **18** (spirits)



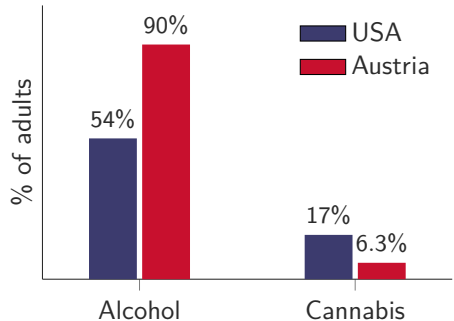
Sources: Gallup Consumption Habits poll (July 2026); Narconon Europe.

Think

Why might this be?

Explanation 1: Cannabis

- 24 U.S. states have legalized cannabis for recreational use
- 17% of U.S. adults use marijuana (Gallup)
- Only 6.3% of Austrian adults (EUDA)
- In Austria, cannabis is still illegal — while Germany partly legalized it in 2024



Sources: Gallup; European Union Drugs Agency (EUDA). Survey definitions differ slightly between sources.

Explanation 2: Alcohol is seen as unhealthier

Text Analysis: Bernhard Maisch, "Alcohol consumption — none is better than a little," *Herz*

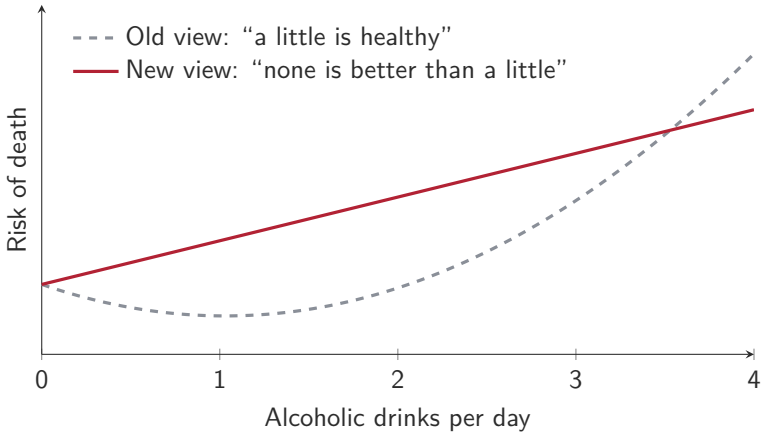
> *"For several decades, epidemiological studies suggested that drinking alcohol in moderate quantities was beneficial. This was referred to as the 'French paradox,' which described differences in mortality between France and Finland mainly, but also other countries, that were found in epidemiological studies. The difference in the levels of alcohol consumption was found to explain the differences in mortality in view of the otherwise similar risk factors. When alcoholic drinks per day were plotted against all-cause mortality this led to a J-shaped curve. This finding represented a window of benefit for moderate alcohol consumption. However, the recent publication by Zhao et al. in 2023 revisited the relationship between the quantity of alcohol consumed and mortality risk and led to a paradigm change, which has influenced not only the recommendations of Canada's Guidance on Alcohol and Health but also the recommendations and guidelines of major health organizations:* ***'No alcohol is better than a little.'*** *. . . "*

Explanation 2: Alcohol is seen as unhealthier

Text Analysis (continued)

> *"... The J-shaped curve as an explanation of the French paradox became a linear relationship between the amount of alcohol consumption and the increasing mortality from tumors and cardiovascular diseases. The renewed review of several control groups in previous epidemiological studies revealed a recruitment error due to the inclusion of abstinent ex-drinkers. Taking this bias into account, the alcohol-friendly view of small amounts of alcohol being cardioprotective had to be revised. The combined misuse of alcohol and other risk factors for carcinogenesis and heart diseases still needs further attention. The misuse of both alcohol and cocaine led to the conclusion that when the two risky substances are consumed together, it is even more detrimental than the mere sum of the two."*

From a J-curve to a straight line



Schematic illustration, not real data.

Official advice: USA vs. Austria

USA

- *"People who do not drink should not start drinking for any reason."*
  — Dietary Guidelines for Americans, 2020–2025
- 2025: the U.S. Surgeon General calls for cancer warning labels on alcohol
- 51% of Americans now say 1–2 drinks a day are *bad* for your health (Gallup, 2026)

Austria

- "Low-risk" limit: **24 g of alcohol per day** for men, 16 g for women
- 24 g $\approx$ **0.6 L of beer** — every day

Living to Work or Working to Live?

Time at work

	USA	Austria
Paid time off (vacation)	10–15 days (average)	**25 days** (legal minimum)
Legal minimum vacation	none	5 weeks
Hours worked per year	1,765	1,611

- **Guess:** Which countries work the *fewest* and the *most* hours?

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Legal minimum vacation	none	5 weeks
Hours worked per year	1,765	1,611

- **Guess:** Which countries work the *fewest* and the *most* hours?

  Fewest: Germany Most: Sudan

Money

	USA	Austria
Average yearly wage	$86,977	$78,301
GDP per person	$95,212	$61,080

Money

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989

of the world's 3,248 billionaires are American

30%

of billionaires — but only about 4% of the world's population

Think

What does this tell us about
American and Austrian working cultures?

Activity: Spectrum Game

Spectrum Game

- You will see a series of statements
- Stand somewhere in the room to show how much you agree or disagree
- Be ready to explain your position!



Strongly disagree Neutral Strongly agree

Statement 1 of 5

A culture of social drinking is a good thing.



Strongly disagree | Neutral | Strongly agree

Statement 2 of 5

The government should not express any religious views.



Strongly disagree | Neutral | Strongly agree

Statement 3 of 5

Shops being closed on Sundays is a good thing, regardless of one's religion.



Strongly disagree Neutral Strongly agree

Statement 4 of 5

It is important to be loyal to one's country.



Strongly disagree | Neutral | Strongly agree

Statement 5 of 5

Work should be the main source of fulfillment in one's life.



Strongly disagree | Neutral | Strongly agree

Thank you!

Questions?